

cover story NUCLEAR DEAL

the rusty Left, but the entire nation with him. His negotiations should not have been with Washington alone; he should have been negotiating with all parties—partners and foes alike. He was not trained for such a political mission.

There was no Narasimha Rao to do the work for him, to do the talking with leaders like Atal Bihari Vajpayee, L.K. Advani, M. Karunanidhi and Sharad Pawar—and of course, the arbiters of AKG Bhavan. Pranab Mukherjee played the mediator to some extent, but he was not the face of the Government—or the party. For the first time in the history of the Congress in power, the leader of the Government is not the leader of the ruling establishment. Well, there seems to be a clear separation of the Church (read 10 Janpath) and the State (read 7 Race Course Road). The prime minister of India is certainly not the prime mover of Indian politics. A nuclear deal is a political deal as well. It requires a political marketer. Sonia Gandhi is supposed to be playing the part. She shows no intention of reaching out to her political adversaries for a national cause. The UPA leader doesn't want to play the national leader, though the nuclear deal has given her a perfect opportunity.

Then the Congress did a huge mistake—and a stupid one at that. It fielded corporate leaders and civil servants as ambassadors of the deal with the brief of winning the Opposition and influencing the media. The BJP leadership was miffed when the EU delegation met Vajpayee to seek his support for the growing Indo-US cooperation. Some of India's top business leaders even went to the US assuring

Essentially a technocrat, the prime minister lacked the political wherewithal to sell the deal to the nation.

its legislators of India's commitment to the nuclear deal. Ronen Sen, India's ambassador to the US, took his assignment so seriously that he questioned the political credibility of those who opposed the deal.

The apolitical prime minister took desperate measures to save a deal he thought would ensure him a place in the front row of history as the moderniser of India. He didn't have the political wherewithal to sell



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his vision. He may have succeeded in his Track Two diplomacy of mobilising corporate India on the deal, but he has failed miserably in repeating the feat politically. When the prime minister was heckled in Parliament in an undignified display of opportunistic opposition, the treasury benches should have seen it coming. In the end it degenerated into a show of us-versus-them, with most of the allies of the Congress watching the fun from the fences.

Still, political follies of the Congress don't make the BJP look any nobler. Politically, BJP has to look more nationalistic than the rest, most certainly the Left. It can't afford to support a deal that rules out the option of nuclear tests. Remember, "atom bomb *banayenge*" was a Jan Sangh slogan. And, as conventional opposition politics goes, it just can't support this Government on its most trumpeted breakthrough. However, the party that is supposed to be on the right side of history has ended up on the right side of the Left, at least in public perception. Ideally, it should have been BJP's moment to take the nuclear high ground. Its tone should have been: look, we set the stage for the deal, and you messed it up. Instead, BJP has almost disowned its legacy as India's first right wing party in power, whose most abiding

